

Our family has been part of Vista for eight years. All five of our children have attended Vista for either part or all of their educational experience, and our two youngest children are currently enrolled. During that time, we have appreciated the opportunities Vista has provided, particularly in the arts and specialty programs that have made the school unique. Unfortunately, over the past two years at Vista, our family has experienced and observed several significant changes that have raised concerns.

One of the first major concerns we experienced was during the 2023–2024 school year when Mrs. Snow left midway through the year. Our middle daughter was in her class and had finally begun succeeding in math after years of struggling. Under Mrs. Snow's instruction, she gained confidence, joined MathCounts, and was making meaningful progress. Her departure created significant disruption for my daughter and many students. We later learned through personal conversations that Mrs. Snow felt disrespected and unsupported regarding concerns she had raised about the Carnegie Math program. About two months after her departure, and after many parents had pulled their children from Vista's in person math courses to put them in online math, Mr. Blasko finally decided the Carnegie Math program was not a good fit for the school and discontinued it.

Following Mrs. Snow's departure, we watched nearly the entire math department leave. Since then, teacher turnover has continued across multiple departments. While we understand that educators leave for many reasons, the number of departures among long-term, highly regarded teachers has been difficult to ignore.

We have seen valued educators leave programs that were once major strengths of the school. Band, Choir, Orchestra, and now after losing Mr. Thomas, the Theater program have all been weakened by the significant teacher turnover. Teachers and staff like Mr. Nickle, Mr. Thomas, Mrs. DeLuca, and Mrs. Fonseca (to name just a few) are not easy to replace. Many of these teachers invested years of their careers at Vista and were deeply committed to the school's mission.

Through conversations with current and former staff members, we have repeatedly heard concerns about burnout, lack of support, and fear surrounding professional disagreement. We have also heard concerns regarding contract renewals and uncertainty about employment decisions. While we cannot independently verify every individual account, the consistency of these concerns across multiple departments has stood out to us.

We have also observed changes in the student environment. Physical education opportunities appear more limited than in previous years. Recess and movement opportunities have been reduced, and lunch periods have become more structured and regulated. While we understand the need for safety and order, these changes have contributed to a school environment that feels more restrictive than what we previously experienced at Vista.

In addition, we had a concerning experience involving our youngest son during the 2025–2026 school year. After reviewing the school's posted policies, we found no prohibition against boys wearing earrings and allowed our son to have his ears pierced. Approximately six weeks later, we received a phone call informing us that a school administrator had removed his earrings after taking him into the hallway, with no antiseptic or gloves. We were told that one ear bled during the process. Neither parent had been contacted beforehand. We were beyond troubled that jewelry was physically removed from our child's body without our knowledge or consent.

When we later discussed the situation with Mr. Blasko, he informed us that this is the policy and it could not be changed. After it was discovered that the policy had not been posted on the school's website, Mr. Blasko's position quickly changed and our son was allowed to wear his earrings the next day. Although the issue was resolved, the experience left us feeling that concerns were addressed only after procedural errors were identified, instead of actual concern for the seriousness of what happened or sincere effort to understand the situation and work with us.

More broadly, we have often left conversations with Mr. Blasko and other administrators feeling reassured in the moment but not genuinely heard in actuality. Over the past two years, this has become a recurring experience for our family as concerns have been raised and discussed.

Taken together, these experiences have changed our perception of Vista. What once felt like a school defined by exceptional teachers, strong programs, and a positive culture now feels increasingly affected by staff turnover, declining morale, and administrative decisions that have greatly impacted both teacher and student opportunities.

We feel there is a great lack of transparency and communication with parents, as well as no significant oversight into parent and teacher concerns in addressing issues properly. We are deeply alarmed and saddened by seeing this deterioration at our beloved Vista.

We ask the board to conduct an independent and thorough review of how the administration is handling parent and teacher concerns, as well as the work environment teachers experience. Teachers should be able to share honest feedback without fear of retaliation. We want to see positive change that includes greater transparency and accountability, and a stronger commitment to respecting and supporting our teachers.

Sincerely,

Ezra and Elise Hurst